

ACT Adjustable Balloons (for Women)

Patient Information · Two adjustable balloons that support the urethra for stress leakage

WARWIKI

The ACT device (Adjustable Continence Therapy) is a small implant for women who leak urine when they cough, laugh, lift or exercise. Two tiny balloons sit on either side of the urethra, near the bladder, to help it close. Like ProACT for men, the balloons can be **adjusted in the office** after surgery.

How It Works

Stress leakage happens when the urethra does not close well during effort. The two balloons add gentle support beside the urethra so it stays closed when you cough or lift. They do not squeeze it shut. Each balloon connects to a small **port** under the skin of the labia. Your team uses the port to add or remove fluid.

Is It Right for Me?

- It is usually considered when earlier leakage surgery has not worked, or the closing muscle of the urethra is weak.
- **It is not approved for women in the United States.** It is used in some other countries, at specialized centers. Ask whether it is available where you are.
- **Problems are common.** European experts warn of a high chance of complications, device failure or removal. Even when it works at first, it often stops working over the years.
- It does not help leakage caused mainly by **prolapse** or an **overactive bladder**.

Learn the Terms

Stress incontinence

Leaking urine when you cough, laugh, lift or exercise.

Urethra

The tube that carries urine out of the body.

Bladder neck

Where the bladder meets the urethra.

Balloon

A small silicone balloon that adds gentle support.

Port

A tiny valve under the skin of the labia used to adjust a balloon.

Adjustment

Adding or removing a little fluid at an office visit.

Weak sphincter

When the muscle that closes the urethra is weak. Doctors call it ISD.

Will it hurt? The balloons are placed during a short operation under anesthesia, through small cuts near the opening of the vagina. You may be sore and swollen for a few days. The later office adjustments are quick and use a small needle at the port.

First days Mild soreness and swelling.	First weeks The balloons heal in place.	Office visits Your team adds fluid a little at a time.	Later Adjust up or down if leakage changes.
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How It's Done

- Using X-ray or ultrasound to guide them, the surgeon places one balloon on each side of the urethra, near the bladder neck.
- The tubes are run to two ports under the skin of the labia.
- The balloons start nearly empty and are left to heal.

Adjusting the Balloons

- A few weeks later, your team adds a little fluid through the port in the office. There is no surgery.
- This may be repeated over several visits until you have good control and can still empty well.
- Leakage improves **gradually**, not always right away.
- Fluid can be removed, and the balloons can be taken out if needed.
- Tell any future surgeon or imaging team that you have the implant.

Call the office that did your surgery if you have:

- A temperature of **100.4 °F (38 °C)** or higher, or chills
- Pain, redness or fluid leaking at a cut or the port
- A weak stream, blood in your urine, or new vaginal pain or discharge

Go to an emergency department if:

- You cannot urinate for several hours and your bladder feels full or painful
- You cannot reach the office and are worried

Three Things to Remember

- ACT uses two balloons to help the urethra close. It is adjusted in the office.
- It is not approved for women in the United States and is offered only at some centers.
- Complications and removal are common. Ask about your other options.